

The application sprint

Week 10, Lecture 1 · Landing the Offer: SWE Job Search for Senior CS Students

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- Why the final week of a search requires a different operating mode
- Concentration over volume: why 15 quality applications beat 60 cold portal submissions
- The daily cadence for a one-week sprint
- Reading your pipeline honestly at week 10 and knowing which levers still move
- Sequencing formal and side-door moves so they reinforce each other

Part 1: running the last mile

Week 10 is a different game

- Weeks 1-9 were preparation: building skills, building materials, building pipeline
- Week 10 is execution: converting everything you built into live conversations
- The switch requires a different operating mode: daily pipeline reviews, shorter feedback loops, faster decisions
- Graham (2013): "Actually startups take off because the founders make them take off." The same logic applies here.

Why the last mile is hard

- Preparation feels productive. Outreach feels exposed.
- Most candidates over-invest in preparation past the point of diminishing return
- At week 10, one more LeetCode problem is worth less than one more referral ask or one more cold message to a specific person
- The goal this week is live conversations, not additional readiness

What a live conversation is

Three things count as a live conversation for the capstone:

1. A scheduled phone screen with a recruiter or engineer
2. An email exchange where a specific role was discussed and a next step was named
3. A referral that produced a direct response from someone at the company

Portal submissions with no reply do not count. The goal is a human on the other end.

Part 2: concentration over volume

Volume thinking vs. concentration thinking

Volume thinking

Concentration thinking

- Submit 60 applications this week
 - Use the same resume and cover message everywhere
 - Apply to every company on the list before worrying about quality
 - Measure success by number of submissions
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- Identify 15 companies where a quality application is possible
 - Use a referral, a specific artifact, or a

Why concentration wins at week 10

- The marginal return on a cold portal application with no side door is low
- A referral-backed application is 4-6x more likely to reach a phone screen (Tech Interview Handbook, 2023)
- At week 10 you have limited time: spending it on high-surface applications beats spreading it thin
- Graham (2013): the most effective moves are the ones that do not scale because they require real attention

Choosing your 15

Three criteria for a quality application at week 10:

1. You have a warm contact, a referral, or a specific open-source foothold
2. You have a public artifact or unconventional move that targets this company specifically
3. You have a tailored cover message that names the team, the problem, or the product feature you care about

If a company fails all three, it is a low-yield target for this week. Add it to next week's list.

Part 3: the daily cadence

The sprint cadence: three blocks per day

Every day of the sprint has the same structure:

1. **Morning pipeline review (30 min):** Read every open thread. Identify any thread that has gone cold for more than 48 hours. Send one follow-up per cold thread. Move any thread that has advanced to a phone screen onto your calendar.
2. **Outreach block (60 min):** Send 2-3 new outreach messages. Each one targets a specific person at a specific company. Not a template blast.
3. **Practice block (45 min):** One timed problem or one 20-minute design sketch. Maintenance, not expansion. You are not learning new patterns this week; you are keeping sharp.

What to do when a thread goes cold

- Wait 48-72 hours after a message with no reply before following up
- One follow-up is appropriate; two is the limit
- The follow-up should add something: a new piece of information, a specific question, or a short note connecting your work to something the company shipped recently
- McKenzie (2012): the negotiating position only exists after a yes. The same is true of the follow-up position: you earn the right to follow up by having been specific the first time.

Tracking the pipeline honestly

Your pipeline has stages: contacted, replied, phone screen scheduled, phone screen done, on-site scheduled, offer, no. At week 10, audit every row:

- Any contact at the “replied” stage for more than a week with no next step: send the follow-up today
- Any company you have not contacted yet: decide right now whether to contact this week or drop it
- Any company where you have a phone screen in the next 10 days: block 3 hours to prepare for that specific company

Part 4: sequencing the formal and side-door tracks

The two tracks, run in parallel

- The formal track: portal applications, recruiter outreach, referral asks that go through a careers link
- The side-door track: referrals from warm contacts, open-source PRs that surface you to engineers, cold emails with a specific artifact, find-a-problem moves
- Both tracks belong in the same week. They are not alternatives; they reinforce each other.
- A side-door move that leads to a warm introduction improves the formal application. The formal application gives the side-door contact something specific to reference.

Sequencing in one week

Day 1-2: Activate the warm contacts. Ask for referrals from the people you know. These take the most lead time.

Day 1-3: Send portal applications to the companies on your list where referrals are not possible.

Day 2-4: Execute the unconventional move. A PR, a cold email with a specific artifact, or a find-a-problem note. This is the highest-variance action: it may not produce a response, but when it does, it is a strong signal.

Day 3-5: Follow up on any thread that has gone cold. Respond same-day to any reply that comes in.

The one unconventional move

Graham (2013) describes moves that do not scale as the highest-signal early investments. In a job search, the unconventional move is that kind of investment:

- An open-source PR merged into a repo the company maintains
- A cold email to a specific engineer with a short artifact that solves a real problem they have
- A blog post or tool that demonstrates exactly the skill set the team is hiring for

One unconventional move at one company beats five generic portal submissions. The capstone requires one. Make it real.

Actually startups take off because the founders make them take off.
There may be a handful that just grew by themselves, but usually it takes some sort of push to get them going.

Take-aways

1. Week 10 is execution, not preparation. The switch requires daily pipeline reviews, shorter feedback loops, and faster decisions.
2. Fifteen quality applications backed by referrals, artifacts, or tailored messages produce more conversations than sixty cold portal submissions.
3. The sprint cadence runs three blocks per day: pipeline review, outreach, maintenance practice.
4. The formal and side-door tracks run in parallel and reinforce each other. Activate warm contacts first; they need the most lead time.
5. One unconventional move at one specific company is the highest-variance action in the sprint. Do it early so the feedback comes back within the week.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 10 reading covers the full two-track playbook, the sprint template, and the personal hiring playbook in one place
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** Demo day and personal playbook: loop review, what worked, what comes next
- **Section (this week):** Mock interview marathon, four back-to-back rounds with peer debrief
- **Capstone (due this week):** Application sprint log, recorded mock loop critique, one unconventional move documented